

miscarriage, poor growth, premature labor, and stillbirth. Most medications for lupus are safe to use during pregnancy, but some aren't, so you need to check with your doctor about whether you need to change your current medication. From around 32 weeks, your baby will be closely monitored and their growth and well-being will be checked. If there are concerns about you or your baby, labor may be induced early, or you may have a planned Cesarean.

High blood pressure Check with your doctor that the medication you are on is safe to use during pregnancy. It's important to continue your medication so that your blood pressure is controlled, because high blood pressure can be dangerous for both you and your baby. Your doctor will frequently check your blood pressure, and will test your urine for protein, because high blood pressure and protein in the urine are symptoms of preeclampsia. Your doctor may also recommend additional scans to check that your baby is growing well.

Thyroid problems If you have an underactive thyroid gland for which you are taking thyroxine, you'll need to have a blood test to ensure that your thyroid is functioning well and that the dose is correct, as thyroxine requirement can increase in pregnancy. It's important that you are not lacking in thyroxine, because this may affect the baby. If you are being treated for an overactive thyroid gland, check with your doctor that you're taking a thyroid medication that is safe in pregnancy. Your thyroid function will be monitored to check that your medication doesn't need to change.

Bowel disease Women with inflammatory bowel conditions, such as ulcerative colitis or Crohn's disease, usually find that their condition improves during pregnancy, although you may relapse after the baby is born. Although it's unusual for bowel conditions to cause major problems during pregnancy, it is important to check that you are not anemic, which can be a side effect of some bowel conditions, and your doctor may recommend extra scans to check that the baby is growing well.

ASK A DOCTOR

I'm asthmatic. Can I use my inhalers during pregnancy?

It's essential that you keep asthma under control in pregnancy, which means continuing to use your inhalers, since the risks from uncontrolled asthma are greater than any risk from taking asthma medication. If asthma is uncontrolled, it can mean that not enough oxygen gets to the baby, leading to a low birth weight or other problems. One of the best ways to control asthma, in addition to taking medication, is to avoid asthma triggers such as pet fur and dust mites. Use air filters, vacuum often, and damp dust; and use duvet, mattress, and pillow protectors. Sometimes, pregnancy reduces the severity of asthma, but if you feel wheezier than usual, talk to your doctor about reviewing your medication.

Homeopathy seems to be a popular form of therapy. How effective is it and is it safe?

Homeopathy works on the principle of treating like with like to stimulate the body's natural healing mechanisms. There has been debate about the efficacy of homeopathy, and the scientific opinion is that there is insufficient evidence to show that it has any effect beyond that of a placebo. But talk to your doctor before using any homeopathic products or remedies during pregnancy, since homeopathy is an area of complementary and alternative medicine that's associated with much debate and scientific controversy. If your doctor gives you the okay, a certified homeopath may be able to provide treatment.

What's the verdict on taking herbal remedies and teas during pregnancy?

The US Food and Drug Administration does not regulate herbs and other dietary supplements, and there's not much research about the health effects of many herbs on pregnant women, so it's